Before you decide on your roof

A homeowner's field guide to a clearer roofing conversation



Representative roofing photograph. No customer project is depicted.

A useful place to begin.

You do not need to arrive with a diagnosis. This guide helps you collect observations, understand the questions behind a scope and prepare for a practical conversation about your home.

Start with the roof you have 3

Observe without climbing 4

Turn a leak into a useful question 5

Understand the repair boundary 6

Compare the work, not the headline 7

Prepare for a calmer first visit 8

Use the questions as notes for your own property. They do not establish its condition or promise a particular service, result or price.

Start with the roof you have

A roof is more than the finish you see from the street. Before comparing new materials, take a little time to describe what is already there.

Think of the covering, its edges and the places where another part of the house meets it. Shingles or tiles are visible; the layers and connections beneath them may not be. A photograph can introduce the conversation, but it cannot show the full condition of that assembly.

Gather any paperwork you already hold: a previous scope, material information or notes about an addition. Missing records are useful to acknowledge too. You do not need to fill the gaps with guesses.

- Name the covering if you know it. Otherwise, share a clear photo from a safe position.
- Describe where a newer porch, room or roof section meets the older house.
- Separate what you have observed from what someone still needs to inspect.

A QUESTION TO KEEP

What do I know about this roof, and what am I still trying to understand?

Observe without climbing

Useful notes can begin indoors or from the ground. You do not have to get onto the roof to explain a concern.

Write down where you first noticed a stain, loose material or debris. Record when you saw it and whether its appearance changed. A mark on a ceiling is a starting point for investigation, not proof that water entered directly above it.

Use views you can reach safely. Avoid climbing onto a roof or moving a ladder to chase a photograph. If something presents an immediate safety concern, stay clear of the affected area and seek appropriate local help.

- Photograph the same visible area again if its appearance changes.
- Mention nearby trees, a chimney or an addition without assuming it caused the problem.
- Keep dates and observations together so the sequence is easy to explain.

A QUESTION TO KEEP

What changed, where did I notice it, and when did it begin?

Turn a leak into a useful question

“There is a leak” starts the conversation. The next useful step is explaining what happens around it.

Describe whether the mark appears during rain, after it, or at another time. Mention nearby plumbing or equipment if relevant, without deciding which system is responsible. Let the assessment establish the source.

Ask how the proposed investigation will distinguish the entry point from the place where water becomes visible. A repair should be explained in terms of the affected connections and surrounding materials, rather than a promise that a product alone will solve every problem.

- Ask which area the team proposes to inspect first and why.
- Request an explanation of what can be seen and what remains concealed.
- Discuss how findings that change the scope will be documented before additional work.

A QUESTION TO KEEP

What evidence would help explain the source, and what is still uncertain?

Understand the repair boundary

A small visible defect does not tell you how far a repair needs to extend. That boundary deserves a clear explanation.

Ask which materials would be removed and which would stay. Connections to the existing roof matter as much as the new material in the middle of a repair. If the surrounding covering is worn or difficult to match, ask how that affects the proposed approach.

A repair and a replacement answer different questions. Ask why the recommended scope suits the observed condition and what it does not address. Do not use appearance alone to decide that every part of the roof needs the same work.

- Identify the connection between the repaired area and the retained roof.
- Discuss appearance differences before materials are chosen.
- Ask what follow-up observations would be useful after the work.

A QUESTION TO KEEP

Where does the proposed work begin and end, and why?

Compare the work, not the headline

Two proposals are easier to compare when they describe the same responsibilities. Start with their scope before focusing on the total.

Read for preparation, material identification, flashing or other connections, cleanup and the parts of the property affected by access. If one proposal is brief, ask for clarification rather than assuming an item is included.

Keep unanswered questions in writing. Discuss how a change will be approved and recorded if an inspection reveals a different condition. Any price, schedule or product commitment must come from the business's actual proposal, not from a general guide.

- Circle unclear inclusions and exclusions.
- Ask which documents identify the materials being proposed.
- Compare responsibility for access, protection and cleanup alongside the work itself.

A QUESTION TO KEEP

Could I explain the difference between these scopes without quoting their prices?

Prepare for a calmer first visit

A short brief helps the conversation stay about your house. Bring the observations, questions and priorities that matter to you.

Explain how the property is reached and point out gates, steps or narrow passages. Discuss occupied rooms, pets and everyday routines that may affect arrangements. Confirm practical details with the contractor rather than assuming them.

Keep your photographs and questions in one place. Ask for the next step to be written down: what will be assessed, what information is needed from you and how the findings will be discussed. You can leave the meeting with a clearer plan even when a final scope is not yet available.

- Share the concern in your own words.
- Bring records you have; say plainly when something is unknown.
- Before agreeing to work, review the written scope and ask about unresolved points.

A QUESTION TO KEEP

Which question would make the next conversation more useful for my home?